liberalisation began: elections were held, sanctions were lifted, and international aid and investments poured in. Facebook was one of the most important players in the new Myanmar, providing millions of Burmese with free access to previously unimaginable troves of information. The relaxation of government control and censorship, however, also led to a rise in ethnic tensions, in particular between the majority Buddhist Burmese and the minority Muslim Rohingya.

The Rohingya are Muslim inhabitants of the Rakhine region, in the west of Myanmar. Since at least the 1970s they have suffered severe discrimination and occasional outbursts of violence from the governing junta and the Buddhist majority. The process of democratisation in the early 2010s raised hopes among the Rohingya that their situation too would improve, but things actually became worse, with waves of sectarian violence and anti-Rohingya pogroms, many inspired by fake news on Facebook.

In 2016–17 a small Islamist organisation known as the Arakan Rohingya Salvation Army (ARSA) carried out a spate of attacks aimed at establishing a separatist Muslim state in Arakan/Rakhine, killing and abducting dozens of non-Muslim civilians and assaulting several army outposts.[8] In response, the Myanmar army and Buddhist extremists launched a full-scale ethnic-cleansing campaign aimed against the entire Rohingya community. They destroyed hundreds of Rohingya villages, killed between 7,000 and 25,000 unarmed civilians, raped or sexually abused between 18,000 and 60,000 women and men, and brutally expelled about 730,000 Rohingya from the country.[9] The violence was fuelled by intense hatred toward all Rohingya. The hatred, in turn, was fomented by anti-Rohingya propaganda, much of it spreading on Facebook, which was by 2016 the main source of news for millions and the most important platform for political mobilisation in Myanmar.[10]

An aid worker called Michael who lived in Myanmar in 2017 described a typical Facebook news feed: ‘The vitriol against the Rohingya was unbelievable online – the amount of it, the violence of it. It was overwhelming … [T]hat’s all that was on people’s news feed in Myanmar at the time. It reinforced the idea that these people were all terrorists not deserving of rights.’[11] In addition to reports of actual ARSA atrocities, Facebook accounts were inundated with fake news about imagined